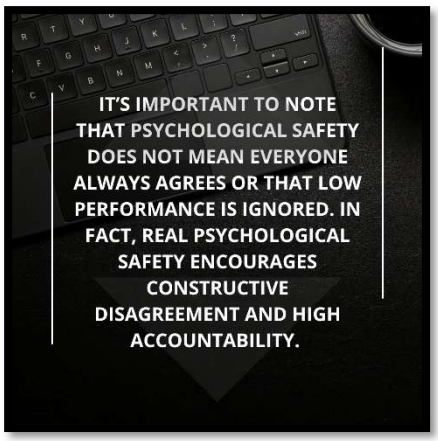
Leadership Tool: Five Steps to Developing Psychological Safety on Teams

Imagine a team meeting where everyone stays silent, afraid that speaking up with a new idea or admitting a mistake will be met with ridicule or punishment. Contrast that with a team where members freely share concerns, brainstorm boldly, and acknowledge errors openly knowing they won't be embarrassed or penalized. The difference between these scenarios is ***psychological safety***, a concept first identified by Harvard professor Amy Edmondson (1999). Edmondson discovered in her early research that the highest-performing teams were *not* those that made no mistakes, but those unafraid to talk about mistakes; better teams "don't make more mistakes, but they are more able to discuss them," a revelation that led to the formal concept of psychological safety. In essence, psychological safety is the shared *belief* that one can speak up with ideas, questions, concerns, or errors without fear of retribution or humiliation. It creates an atmosphere of trust and openness, where team members feel *safe* to be themselves and take interpersonal risks.

Psychological safety has quickly become recognized as a cornerstone of effective, innovative teams. Google's famous *Project Aristotle* study (Duhigg, 2016). found that psychological safety was "by far the most important" factor distinguishing high-performing teams from the rest. When team members feel safe, they engage in the very behaviors that drive success: they take moderate risks, propose creative ideas, admit uncertainties, and constructively challenge each other without the fear of having their "neck cut off" for speaking up (Delizonna, 2017). Research shows such an environment boosts engagement, learning, and even employee well-being (Hallam et al., 2023). On the other hand, a lack of psychological safety causes people to hold back, leading to lost ideas, lack of trust, and even higher turnover. Given the clear benefits, the question for leaders and teams is *how* to cultivate this kind of climate.

Understanding Psychological Safety



Psychological safety is more than just "being nice" or avoiding conflict—it's about creating a climate where *candor* and *respect* coexist. Edmondson defines a psychologically safe workplace as one where people feel they can "do my job without fear of humiliation or punishment" for speaking up with ideas or concerns (Edmondson, 1999). In a group with high psychological safety, team members feel comfortable asking for help, admitting mistakes, or disagreeing with the status quo without dread of negative consequences. Team members in a psychologically safe environment can raise problems and debate ideas openly because they know they won't be punished or ostracized for speaking their minds. At the same time, they

understand that everyone will be treated with respect and that mistakes will be viewed as opportunities to learn rather than occasions for blame.

Fostering this climate requires deliberate effort. Research in organizational psychology highlights several key elements that contribute to a sense of psychological safety on a team. These include trust among colleagues, effective communication practices, supportive leadership behavior, respectful peer interactions, and healthy attitudes toward feedback and failure (Hallam et al., 2023). In short, psychological safety is a *group property* that emerges from consistent behaviors and norms — set by leaders and reinforced by team members — that make it safe for everyone to contribute.

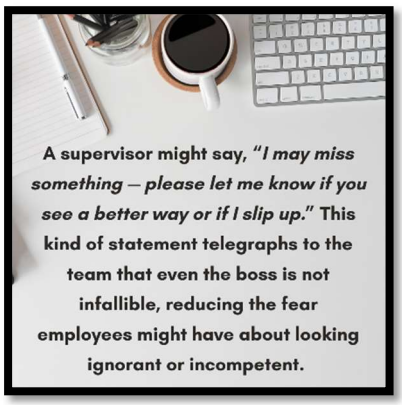
Given its importance, how can leaders and team members work together to establish and sustain psychological safety? Outlined below are best practices and concrete steps, grounded in research, that a team leader can implement, and a team can embrace. These steps range from how a leader sets the tone on day one, to daily communication habits, to how the team handles mistakes and feedback. By following these practices, any team can cultivate a climate of trust and openness where everyone feels safe to do their best work.

Step 1: Set the Stage by Framing and Modeling Safety

The first step in building psychological safety is for leaders to *set the stage*—establish the context and expectations that signal to the team: *This is a safe environment to speak up*. Leaders shape the narrative of how the team approaches its work. Research suggests that leaders should frame the work as a learning challenge rather than an execution task (Edmondson, 2018). Emphasize that the problems you're tackling are complex, that uncertainty exists, and thus everyone's input is valuable and necessary for success. By explicitly highlighting that *no one* has all the answers and that the team must learn together, you create a rationale for people to speak up. This approach reframes speaking up from being a risk to being a responsibility in service of the team's goals.

> ***For example, a leader might say at a project kickoff, "We've never done this before, so we're going to learn as we go — and we need everybody's ideas and observations to find the best path forward."***

Crucially, team leaders must also model the behavior of *fallibility and humility*. In a psychologically safe climate, the leader openly acknowledges that they too make mistakes and don't know everything. Edmondson (2018) advises leaders to model vulnerability — for instance, admit when you're unsure or have made an error — to signal that it's okay to be imperfect. Research shows that when leaders act with humility and openness, teams report higher psychological safety (Edmondson, 2018).



In setting the stage, it also helps to explicitly discuss what psychological safety means and why it matters. Don't assume everyone immediately understands the concept. A best practice is to talk about psychological safety openly and make it a team priority. You might introduce the idea in a meeting, clarify that it means an environment of respect and candor, and dispel common misconceptions (for example, that it means being "comfortable" all the time or avoiding hard feedback). By putting psychological safety on the agenda, leaders show they *care* about it. The key in this first step is that leadership sets a tone of trust, learning, and openness from the outset. Team members take their cues from this. When a leader frames challenges as learning opportunities and is candid about their own learning process, it encourages everyone on the team to do the same.

Step 2: Invite Participation and Open Dialogue

Once you've set the stage, the next step is to actively invite participation and create channels for open dialogue. Psychological safety flourishes when team members feel *explicitly encouraged* to contribute. Leaders should go beyond saying "my door is always open" — they must proactively solicit input and show that every voice is valued. One simple but powerful habit is to ask open-ended questions that draw out people's ideas and concerns. Research indicates that when leaders ask genuine questions and *listen actively* to the answers, it sends a strong signal that speaking up is welcomed, not begrudged (Sowcik, 2022).

Instead of the perfunctory "Any questions?" at the end of a discussion (which often yields silence), try asking specific, inviting questions like, "What are we missing?" or "Who sees a risk or a different perspective we haven't considered?".

It's also important to create multiple avenues for participation, recognizing that not everyone is comfortable speaking in the same forum. Some team members might voice ideas more freely one-on-one than in a big group meeting; others might prefer writing down their input. Provide diverse channels for people to contribute: team brainstorming sessions, anonymous suggestion boxes or online forums, and regular one-on-one check-ins. In team meetings, you can ensure everyone gets airtime by explicitly inviting quieter members to share ("I'd love to hear from those who haven't spoken yet") and by rotating meeting roles so that all members practice active engagement.

Another crucial aspect is how leaders respond in the moment to input. When someone does speak up with an idea or concern, thank them for it. Acknowledging contributions warmly, even if you don't ultimately agree with or adopt them, will encourage more participation.

From a team perspective, establishing norms of active listening and respectful discussion supports this open dialogue. Team members should practice not interrupting each other, truly listening to understand different viewpoints, and building on each other's ideas. Leaders can encourage this by facilitating discussions (for instance, summarizing what someone said and affirming it before moving to another person's comment). Some teams adopt guidelines like *"listen more, speak less"* and *"build on others' contributions"* to foster a collaborative conversational style (Cote, 2025). These

norms make it clear that everyone's input is wanted and valued. Over time, as the habit of open dialogue takes root, team members will start inviting each other's opinions, not just relying on the leader to do so. That is a sign of a truly psychologically safe team.

Step 3: Respond to Mistakes and Input Constructively

How a team responds when someone does speak up or when something goes wrong is the make-or-break factor for psychological safety. A leader's reaction "determines whether psychological safety grows or erodes" after that moment (Edmondson, 2018). Thus, the third step is to consistently respond to employee input, questions, and even mistakes in a *constructive, appreciative* manner. In a psychologically safe team, blame is replaced with curiosity. When a mistake comes to light or a problem is raised, the immediate response should be to understand and learn, not to scold or assign shame. By treating mistakes as data for improvement, you reinforce the message that the act of *speaking up* about an issue is welcome – even if the news is bad.

In practice, here are some constructive behaviors both leaders and team members can use when responding to mistakes or input:

- **Express appreciation first:** If someone voices a concern or confesses an error, start by thanking them for their honesty and courage. *"I appreciate you bringing this up"* signals that their voice is valued, even if the news is difficult.
- **Focus on solutions, not blame:** Instead of asking *"Who's fault is this?"*, shift to *"What factors contributed to this outcome and how can we fix it going forward?"*. This turns a potentially defensive conversation into a collaborative problem-solving session.
- **Normalize error as part of growth:** Share examples of your own past mistakes and what you learned, to destigmatize failure. When team members see leaders openly reflecting on their missteps, it reinforces that *nobody is expected to be perfect*.
- **Give feedback respectfully and constructively:** Even when corrective feedback is needed, frame it as coaching. For instance, *"I noticed X didn't go as planned. How can we support you in doing Y differently next time?"* This way, feedback is about the work, not a personal attack, and it's oriented toward improvement.
- **Follow up and close the loop:** If an issue was raised, let the team know how it was addressed. Similarly, if a suggestion was implemented or a risk mitigated thanks to someone speaking up, acknowledge that publicly. This creates a clear link between speaking up and positive outcomes.

By responding to input and mistakes in this productive manner, leaders build **trust**. Over time, team members learn *through experience* that "If I speak up or admit an error here, I won't be punished — in fact, it leads to something good." That trust is the bedrock of psychological safety.

Step 4: Encourage Peer Support and Inclusive Team Norms

While leadership behavior is a major driver, psychological safety is ultimately a team property, meaning it also depends on how team members treat one another. Thus, fostering peer-to-peer support and inclusive norms is the fourth crucial step. Everyone on the team should understand that they contribute to either a safe climate or an unsafe one, through everyday interactions.

The following are some basic foundational elements for the entire team to embrace:

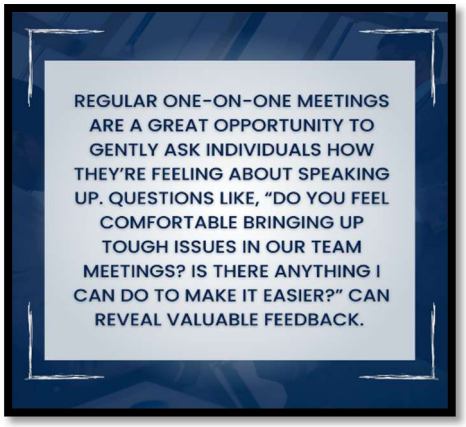
- **Mutual respect:** Teammates should show respect for each other's perspectives, even when they disagree. This involves active listening, polite discourse, and avoiding disparaging or sarcastic remarks about others' ideas.
- **Willingness to help:** Research identifies a "willingness to help" among colleagues as a key element of psychological safety (Cote, 2025; Edmondson, 2018). This means team members feel *comfortable asking for help* when needed, and they trust that others will not ridicule or reject the request but rather willingly provide assistance. Teams can cultivate this by openly encouraging people to reach out when they're stuck and by rewarding collaboration over solo heroics.
- **Everyone's voice is heard and valued:** Teams that are psychologically safe tend to have an *equal* (or at least equitable) distribution of voice, rather than one or two people dominating every conversation. Leaders should be mindful of participation equity: invite input from quieter members and encourage those who typically speak often to also practice listening. Peer norms can support this; for instance, team members can agree to signal if someone hasn't had a chance to speak or amplify a colleague's point if it was talked.

In summary, teams build psychological safety not just through top-down leadership actions but through a culture of support that is co-created by all members. By practicing empathy, respect, and trust with each other daily, colleagues reinforce the safety net — catching each other when someone takes a risk.

Step 5: Reflect, Measure, and Sustain the Safety Culture

Building psychological safety is not a one-time task but an ongoing commitment. The final step involves reflecting on the team's climate, measuring progress, and making adjustments to

continuously improve and sustain psychological safety over the long run. It's useful for leaders to periodically take a step back and ask, *"How safe do people feel speaking up on our team right now?"*



Demonstrating that you *want* to hear if people feel unsafe is, in itself, a trust-building action. It shows you take psychological safety seriously. If you do receive feedback about problematic areas (say an individual mentions that discussions often get dominated by a few voices, making others reluctant to chime in), be sure to act on it and later communicate what changes you'll implement. This closing of the feedback loop reinforces that honesty is rewarded.

Finally, adjust as the team evolves. New members joining, organizational changes, or high-pressure periods can all impact the team's sense of safety. Savvy leaders remain vigilant and adaptive, re-emphasizing psychological safety during transitions. They may revisit Step 1 and re-establish the norms with a new group or during a challenging project, or they might introduce new practices to bolster safety. The key is to never assume "we're good now" and let it fall off the agenda. By continually reassessing and making psychological safety an ongoing priority, leaders and teams can ensure that this invaluable aspect of their culture not only takes root but also thrives over time.

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